



Jalal Al Hussein, Valentina Napolitano & Norig Neveu (eds.). *Migrations in Jordan: Reception Policies and Settlement Strategies*. London: I.B. Tauris. 2024. 285 pp. ISBN 978-0-7556-0684-9. \$115.00 (Hardback).

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Migrations in Jordan: Reception Policies and Settlement Strategies is a significant and timely contribution to Middle Eastern migration studies, offering a rare long-term, multiscale, and migrant-centred examination of the multiple waves of displacement that have shaped Jordan from the late Ottoman period to the present. This volume is an outcome of the collective multidisciplinary research program *Lajeh*, sponsored by the French national research agency (ANR) at the French Institute of the Near East in Amman (Ifpo), between 2016 and 2019. The editors – Jalal Al Hussein (Ifpo), Valentina Napolitano (IRD), and Norig Neveu (IREMAM/CNRS) – bring together here anthropology, geography, political science, history, and urban studies to produce a study that is both methodologically innovative and conceptually ambitious, since no comprehensive study had yet been dedicated to the Jordanian case before.¹

Featuring twelve chapters, the volume is divided into three parts: the first focuses on host authorities and international organization policies, while the second deals with urban dynamics, intermingling, and space production. Eventually, the third is dedicated to social reconfigurations, analysing solidarity networks, and humanitarian practices in the country. The twenty-page introduction, which frames the book's objectives and analytical architecture, shows why such a cumulative and historically grounded perspective is indispensable for understanding migration governance and settlement in the Hashemite Kingdom. In their argument, the editors immediately foreground Jordan's unique demographic landscape: nearly a third of its eleven million inhabitants are refugees, primarily Palestinians and Syrians, alongside Iraqis, Yemenis, Sudanese, and Somalis. This demographic fact is not treated as an anomaly but as the outcome of over a century of cross-border movements linked to empire, state formation, conflict, and economic circulation. By situating the country within a *longue durée* of mobility – including Circassian and Chechen arrivals in the late nineteenth century and Armenian and Syrian migrations during the British Mandate on the Emirate of Transjordan (1922-1946) – the introduction contests narratives portraying contemporary displacement as unprecedented.² Instead, it presents Jordan as a territory shaped by successive migration regimes that have interacted with state-building, urbanization, and regional geopolitics.

¹ Until now, monographic studies on refugees in Jordan have only been devoted to very specific cases and, in the first place, to the Palestinians' conditions. Among these works, one can quote Twigt, 2022 and Gandolfo, 2012.

² A useful discussion of how to deconstruct the very notion of a "migration crisis" can be found in Mayblin & Turner, 2020.

This historical layering is central to the book's conceptual contribution: refugee policies in Jordan are not isolated responses to discrete crises but cumulative outcomes of earlier reception strategies, administrative precedents, and shifting notions of national belonging. One of the introduction's most compelling aspects is its methodological shift from traditional transnational migration approaches – which emphasize border-crossing networks – to a *reterritorialized* analysis locating migrant agency within the national field. While acknowledging the importance of transnational ties, the editors insist on the decisive role of the host state, especially a state like Jordan that is *not* a signatory to the 1951 Refugee Convention or its 1967 Protocol.³ This situates migration governance within a realistic political economy of national interests, bureaucratic discretion, and humanitarian negotiation. At the same time, the editors place migrants' strategies and perceptions at the centre of their analysis. Migrants, here, are not passive recipients of aid or objects of state management; they are actors who draw on family networks, professional circuits, religious solidarities, and historical mobilities to shape their own settlement trajectories. This analytical balance – between state-centric and agency-centred perspectives – is one of the volume's greatest intellectual strengths.

A second major intervention is the critique of the classical opposition between “forced” and “voluntary” migration. The editors argue that long-term analysis of exile reveals fluidity, not fixity: individuals may move along a continuum of motivations and legal statuses over time. The same group may be treated alternatively as refugees, guests, workers, or undesirables depending on shifting geopolitical contexts and administrative categorizations. Jordan offers particularly rich empirical ground for this argument: the volume traces the divergent legal pathways of Palestinians (refugees who became citizens), ex-Gazans (a group left in legal limbo), and Syrians, Iraqis, Yemenis, Sudanese, and Somalis who are formally “guests” yet often remain indefinitely. These differences are not merely bureaucratic; they produce hierarchies of access to education, employment, public services, and political participation.

The first part of the book explores precisely this paradoxical dynamic, through the lens of host-state governance and international humanitarian frameworks. Lillian Frost's chapter addresses the category of “protracted refugees,” showing how the rights offered to Palestinians have historically mirrored those available to Jordanians, while simultaneously producing ambiguities and internal political tensions within the Jordanian polity. This discussion highlights how citizenship, far from being a stable legal status, becomes a contested terrain where national identity, regional politics, and humanitarian discourses intersect. The following chapter, by Jalal Al Hussein and Anna Kvittingen, deepens this reflection by examining the case of refugees from Gaza, who

³ To understand how reception and welcoming legislation works, instead, in Muslim countries, see Shoukri, 2010.

have remained legally non-citizens since the Naksa of 1967. Their analysis exposes the paradox of a state policy that justifies its restrictive framework in the name of preserving refugees' right of return, thereby reinforcing socio-economic marginalization while simultaneously managing potential threats to political stability. Solenn Al Majali's contribution shifts the focus to Yemeni refugees, whose situation exemplifies what the editors call a "non-reception" policy. After 2015, Yemenis faced tightening visa restrictions and the threat of deportation, conditions that effectively rendered their presence illegal. Majali shows how humanitarian categorization—specifically the labelling of Yemenis as "non-Syrian refugees"—has material consequences, shaping migrants' access to resources and exposing them to new forms of institutional violence. The final chapter of this section, by David Lagarde and Kamel Doraï, reconstructs the evolving migration routes of Syrian street traders. Their work illustrates how early reliance on family and professional networks was gradually replaced by weak ties with smugglers and local institutional actors as border regimes hardened after 2014. The chapter shows how shifting state policies reverberate through refugee strategies, recalibrating socio-economic trajectories in real time.

Another notable contribution of this work is the integration of urban studies into migration analysis, as the second section of the study turns specifically to the spatial consequences of displacement. The editors argue that refugees have been central – not incidental – to Jordan's state and nation building, contributing to the production of urban and semi-urban environments. From Circassians shaping the topography and the architecture of early Amman, to Palestinian camps functioning as engines of urban expansion and labour supply, refugees have influenced the material, social, and political geography of the country. Gaspard Vial-Benamra's first contribution provides, for instance, a historical account of Chechen migration to Transjordan, highlighting the role of kinship, confessional, and ethnic networks in building agricultural settlements and participating in early state formation. His chapter uncovers a largely understudied dimension of Jordanian history, showing how migrant groups shaped urban development and municipal structures from the late Ottoman period onward. The following studies by Ayham Dalal and Aline Fraikin, as well as by Myriam Ababsa and Héloïse Peaucelle, consequently revisit the question of camps and urbanization. By drawing on theoretical frameworks such as Foucault's biopower and Agamben's state of exception, the authors show how refugee camps function as spaces of control but also as evolving socio-political environments embedded within the national urban fabric. Palestinian camps, in particular, remain emblematic both of political dispossession and of gradual urban integration over decades, while the absence of camps for Iraqi refugees is interpreted as a deliberate political choice to discourage long-term settlement and limit humanitarian mobilization in the aftermath of the Nakba. The arrival of Syrians in 2012 renewed debates about encampment, leading to the rapid construction of numerous

camps and reception centres. The chapters in this section collectively show that spatial policies cannot be separated from the political calculus of host-state authorities: decisions about land allocation, camp design, or urban housing programs directly mediate the intensity of social interactions between refugees and host communities. This focus distinguishes the volume from humanitarian literature that frames camps as isolated exceptions. Instead, it shows how settlement policies shape space (e.g., the shift from open to closed Syrian camps), refugees reshape cities (e.g., “Little Daraa” in Irbid), and humanitarian programs themselves generate new urban dynamics, including social cohesion initiatives and housing developments. The spatial perspective, therefore, enriches our understanding of how migration governance is materially instantiated in landscapes, infrastructures, and urban life.

The third thematic axis concerns social reconfigurations produced by migration as well as migrants themselves. The first chapter in this section, by Ann-Christin Zuntz, highlights the gendered dimensions of transnational family dynamics during the Syrian conflict, showing how displacement reshapes female labour and care networks, underscoring how migrant women’s strategies respond not only to domestic pressures but also to structural constraints in the Jordanian labour market⁴ and humanitarian sector, with its livelihood programs. Norig Neveu’s chapter on Christian Iraqis then offers one of the volume’s most compelling case studies of faith-based solidarity. She shows how religious actors—priests, charities, transnational clerical networks—play a central role in filling the gaps left by state and international institutions. The final chapter—by Oroub El Abed, Zoë Jordan, and Yasmeen Shahzadeh—studies youth associations and cultural spaces founded in Amman, demonstrating how mixed groups of Syrian, Iraqi, and Jordanian young people create new forms of sociability, intellectual engagement, and urban belonging. These initiatives, often launched by refugees themselves or by second-generation migrants, testify to the creative potential of displacement, particularly when institutional support remains limited. As the editors note, such grassroots projects allow researchers to trace a genealogy of local assistance networks that cut across different waves of migration. These phenomena challenge conventional humanitarian frameworks that view refugees as beneficiaries rather than providers of aid. They also illuminate an often-overlooked aspect: how displaced populations contribute to the moral and social fabric of the host society.

One of the introduction’s most persuasive claims is that Jordan constitutes an exceptional laboratory for studying refugee governance. Because the country has received so many migration waves of varying scale, origin, and legal treatment, it offers an ideal site for comparative and historical analyses. The editors carefully outline how different

⁴ For further information on the labour market in the Hashemite Kingdom please refer to Krafft & Assaad, 2019.

chapters show: the evolution of legal categories (citizen, guest, refugee, displaced); the effects of border closures, visa regimes, and humanitarian labelling; and the frictions between national security logics and international protection norms. This reveals how each migration wave has influenced subsequent policies. For instance, the Palestinian experience shapes contemporary hesitation to grant rights that could be interpreted as facilitating permanent settlement for Syrians or Iraqis.

Overall, the conclusion of the volume, by Kamel Dorai, shows that *Migrations in Jordan* is more than a compilation of case studies: it provides a conceptual framework for understanding how states and migrants co-produce migration regimes over time. The editors succeed in articulating a perspective that is simultaneously historical, multiscale, and grounded in empirical research. Its main strengths include: the integration of disciplines, in a rare and productive way; the use of a long-term perspective, whose historical depth prevents simplistic crisis-oriented narratives; its empirical richness, drawing from ethnography, archival materials, cartography, and institutional documents; and, finally, its analytical nuance, whose refusal of rigid categorizations (forced/voluntary, refugee/economic migrant) reflects contemporary theoretical advances. If there is a limitation, it lies in the inevitable challenge of balancing so many migratory contexts. Some readers may wish for more explicit comparative hypotheses or more direct engagement with global migration regimes beyond the Middle Eastern and European frameworks referenced. Yet this minor critique does not detract from the volume's significance, which constitutes a unique, seminal work on the Jordanian context. *Migrations in Jordan* is indeed a landmark study of migration governance, settlement strategies, and the historical entanglement between refugees and the Jordanian state. Its multiscale, migrant-centred, and historically grounded approach makes the volume a reference for scholars of forced migration, Middle Eastern studies, urban sociology, and humanitarian governance.

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